THE VOICEBUILDING METHOD

Tension-Release Vocal Warm-Up

The Mix Voice warm-up I run with every singer, before we ever touch a song.

BY NANDO | NANDOVOCALCOACH.COM

My Story in 30 Seconds

I was studying to be an Opera singer when a doctor told me I had to stop. My muscles were fighting against each other every time I sang, something called Muscle Tension Dysphonia (MTD). I tried everything, straining, clenching, pushing, opening, not opening. Not because I didn't know the technique. Because knowing it and getting my body to do it turned out to be two completely different things.

What saved me wasn't more singing. It was training smarter. This is how I did it.

Think of it the way athletes think of warm-ups. You don't walk into a gym and max out on day one. You prepare the body, load progressively, and cool down. Your voice is no different.

The Routine: 10 Minutes Total

Before you start: Find a quiet space. Stand tall. No forcing, no pushing. If something hurts, stop.

1 Neck, Tongue & Jaw Release

5 min

The bodywork I build into almost every session, one way or another. Grab a small cloth, napkin, or hand towel, you'll need it for two of these.

SCM massage: Fingers along the sides of your neck, from behind your ear down to your collarbone. Gentle circular pressure, 20–30 seconds each side.

Tongue root massage: Find the soft spot right under your chin, just above where your hyoid bone sits. Press your fingertips in and drag gently downward, you're reaching the tongue root, mylohyoid, and digastric muscles. Don't be too gentle, but don't hurt yourself either. Keep breathing through it.

Tongue pull: Wrap the cloth around your tongue for grip. Pull it gently out and down while you look up and keep breathing. Hold 30 seconds. 2 reps.

Jaw stretch: Bite down gently on the rolled cloth with your lower teeth, then tilt your head back and look up. Hold 30 seconds. 2 reps.

Why it works: Your tongue root, jaw, neck, and larynx are connected by the same muscular chain, tension in any one shows up as tension in your voice. This isn't warm-up fluff, it's mobility work for muscles that need to be loose before you sing a note.

Do: About 5 minutes total, unrushed. Both sides for the massages, 2 reps each for the stretches.

2 Siren Glide

2 min

The exercise that removes the break in your voice.

Glide continuously from your lowest comfortable note to your highest and back down on an "eee-ooo" sound, like a siren. No stopping, no jumping, just a smooth slide.

Why it works: Your voice runs on two mechanisms, one built for low notes, one for high notes. Most "breaks" happen because the voice jumps between them instead of blending. The siren forces a smooth handoff, so your coordination learns the transition instead of the jump.

Do: 4–5 full glides, slow enough that you stay in control the whole way up and down.

3 Straw Glide: Building Your Mix

3 min

The tool I reach for with almost every singer, every session.

Grab a regular straw (a Blowfish if you have one, but any straw works, no water needed). Sing a comfortable vowel through it, staying right in the middle of your range, not your top or bottom. Small glides up and down, just a few notes at a time.

The goal here isn't range. It's comfort. Find the spot in your middle voice that feels the least stable, the least "yours," and just get used to being there.

Why it works: SOVT (semi-occluded vocal tract) reduces the muscular effort it takes to phonate, so you can explore the part of your range that usually feels weakest without adding strain to reach it. That middle zone is where mix voice lives, and it's the part most singers avoid because it feels unstable. You get used to it by hanging out there safely, not by pushing through it.

Do: 2–3 minutes, small glides, comfortable range only. If it stops feeling comfortable, you've gone too far, come back to center.

Do this before every singing practice or performance.

It takes 10 minutes. It's the exact sequence I run in session one with every student. Consistency beats intensity. Every single time.

What's Next?

This routine builds the foundation. In your personalized sessions with me, we go deeper:

- **Finding your specific vocal pattern:** where your tension actually lives, why your breaks happen where they do
- **Targeted exercises for YOUR imbalance**, not a generic routine, the specific fix your voice needs
- **Training progressively** so your voice gets stronger, not just warmed up

Book your first session at nandovocalcoach.com

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Inspired by the work of Ingo Titze, Ph.D. and the field of vocology.